

Synergies Run and Share — Deep Research Report

Prepared for: IT Procurement Lead, Head of Data, AI and Digital

Contents

1. Company at a glance
2. Strategic direction
3. Industry forces
4. Regulatory and compliance frame
5. The procurement and data leader's world at SRS
6. Peer signals
7. Friction map

Challenge cards

Where this document is thin

1. Company at a glance

SRS, Synergies Run and Share, is a grouping of companies drawn mainly from retail distribution, whose stated purpose is to encourage the exchange of good practice and inter-banner pooling in indirect purchasing — what French practice calls non-merchandise buying. It is not a retailer and does not present itself as a conventional procurement outsourcer; it describes its own role as an interface, facilitating win-win partnerships between its member groups and suppliers on the strength of aggregated volumes.

The scale reported is network scale rather than operating-company scale. SRS states 1,500 collaborators drawn from more than 20 shareholder groups, 50 working groups organised as synergy projects, and nine activity families. Separately it states that more than 1,000 people from member banners are involved and that they collectively account for more than €1 billion of indirect purchasing each year across more than 50 themes. Those two headcount figures are not the same measure and should not be added together or used interchangeably.

The nine activity families are communications; information systems and telephony; transport and logistics; travel; sustainability and innovation; human resources; construction and equipment; workplace environment; and finance and legal. SRS says the domains it covers evolve continuously according to member needs, and that it invites members to pool knowledge across all their markets — naming France, Spain, Belgium, Portugal, Italy, Poland, Romania and Brazil.

Two details are worth carrying into the room. The registered address is 53 rue du Maréchal de Lattre de Tassigny in Croix, in the Lille conurbation and at the heart of the Mulliez family's corporate geography; and 2026 recruitment material names Leroy Merlin, Auchan and Decathlon among member banners, all three being Association Familiale Mulliez companies, while describing SRS as an ecosystem of more than one hundred distribution banners in France and internationally. SRS's own public language is nonetheless "more than 20 shareholder groups", and no public source establishes which groups hold which stakes or how governance and escalation work.

One correction to a common assumption: SRS already operates a member-facing application with its own login at app.srs-net.com. The 2026 hiring material describing a new collaborative digital platform therefore describes an evolution of something that exists rather than a first system, though nothing public establishes the current platform's adoption, production status or user numbers.

Questions to ask on the day:

- Which parts of the network are governed centrally by SRS, and which remain fully local to member groups?
- Where does SRS create the most measurable value today — negotiated economics, risk reduction, speed, or knowledge sharing?
- Has the member footprint changed materially in the last twenty-four months?

2. Strategic direction

The public strategic language is explicit and short: together faster and further. SRS says its purpose is to create links between member companies and optimise performance around a shared vision, and that its working groups are organised as synergy projects whose purchasing themes evolve continuously according to member needs.

The stronger current signal comes from 2026 recruitment material, which places human and digital capability at the centre of future synergies and describes work around a collaborative digital platform: data governance, classification, archiving and migration of content, solution benchmarking, tender drafting, comparative evaluation of offers, testing and stakeholder coordination. That list is worth reading closely, because it is essentially a description of the information problem the organisation is trying to solve — governing the knowledge base, then using it to run better sourcing.

The direction that public evidence supports is a move from a network of people and purchasing groups toward a more structured digital knowledge and collaboration layer. What public evidence does not establish is whether that initiative is live, scaled or strategically central, and there is no annual report, investor presentation or published multi-year strategy against which to test it.

Questions to ask on the day:

- Is the platform effort primarily about community collaboration, procurement execution, data, or all three?
- Which strategic outcomes matter most over the next two years?
- What has changed in the operating model as the member base and international footprint have grown?

3. Industry forces

Procurement is under simultaneous pressure to cut cost, manage supplier risk, improve business alignment and adopt AI, and the barriers are organisational rather than technical. Deloitte's 2025 chief procurement officer survey, covering more than 250 CPOs across 40 countries, identifies siloed working, competing priorities, execution capability and talent gaps among the leading obstacles to delivering value. Gartner's 2026 procurement research places supplier risk alongside cost savings as a leading priority and ties procurement resilience to a volatile, AI-shaped and geopolitically uncertain environment.

Data readiness is the gating issue for AI in procurement, and the number is stark: Gartner reported that 74% of procurement leaders surveyed said their data was not AI-ready. That single figure reframes most AI conversations in this function — the constraint is upstream of the model.

Supplier information is becoming a management asset rather than a compliance appendix. Professional body material through 2025 and 2026 emphasises continuous supplier risk monitoring combining internal and external data, data hygiene, and human oversight of automated assessment. The shift is from periodic scorecards to something closer to continuous visibility, which raises the volume of evidence in circulation rather than lowering it.

Sustainability adds a recurring information load that lands squarely on procurement. Supplier engagement, climate data and human-rights due diligence all depend on collecting comparable information across large supplier bases, and the regulatory simplification of 2026 has changed what must be collected without removing the underlying need.

For a network such as SRS these forces compound in a specific way. The business model multiplies the benefit of shared information and simultaneously multiplies the cost of inconsistent definitions, duplicated requests, divergent member requirements and fragmented evidence. Pooling only pays when the pooled thing is comparable.

Questions to ask on the day:

- Which of these pressures is changing procurement work most sharply for members?
- Where does cross-member standardisation create value, and where does it create resistance?
- Which data sets are hardest to keep comparable across countries or member organisations?

4. Regulatory and compliance frame

Four instruments matter here, and two of them moved during 2026 in ways that change what needs doing now.

The AI Act timetable is lighter than the headline suggests. The Digital Omnibus on AI, Regulation (EU) 2026/1744, entered into force on 27 July 2026 and deferred high-risk obligations for stand-alone Annex III systems from 2 August 2026 to 2 December 2027, and for AI embedded in regulated Annex I products to 2 August 2028. What did begin on 2 August 2026 is the Article 50 transparency regime, alongside the prohibited-practices rules in force since February 2025, the AI literacy duty, and the general-purpose AI provider obligations that have applied since August 2025. For a procurement function the practical reading is that supplier clauses on high-risk classification, conformity assessment and technical documentation have more runway than expected, while transparency, literacy and prohibited-practice obligations are live now. It also means any supplier claiming a hard August 2026 compliance deadline as a reason for pricing or scope should be

questioned.

Sustainability reporting was simplified twice and the second change is the one that helps a procurement network. The Omnibus I Directive, Directive (EU) 2026/470, in force since 18 March 2026, raised CSRD thresholds to more than 1,000 employees and more than €450 million net turnover, applying to financial years beginning on or after 1 January 2027, and raised due diligence thresholds to more than 5,000 employees and more than €1.5 billion, with member state transposition by 26 July 2028 and application to companies from 26 July 2029. On 3 July 2026 the Commission adopted the revised European Sustainability Reporting Standards alongside a voluntary standard for smaller companies, cutting mandatory data points by around 60% and expected to apply mandatorily from financial year 2027 with early adoption permitted for 2026 once the scrutiny period closes.

The provision most relevant to indirect procurement is the value-chain cap. Companies not exceeding 1,000 employees cannot be required to provide sustainability information beyond the Commission's voluntary standard, have a statutory right to decline, and contrary contractual clauses are not binding — with the requester obliged to tell them what exceeds the standard and that the right exists. For a grouping that sits between large reporting members and a long tail of smaller suppliers, that is both a shield and an obligation: it caps what can be demanded of small suppliers, and it puts a duty on whoever is doing the asking.

GDPR remains the baseline for personal-data processing, with the usual principles and, more pointedly for this organisation, the processor requirements: contractual safeguards, documented instructions and a clear allocation of controller and processor roles. In a shared-service model that allocation is rarely obvious and is worth establishing explicitly rather than by default.

NIS2 applies to medium and large entities in specified sectors including certain digital and ICT service providers, with scope depending on activity, size and national implementation. France had still not promulgated its transposition law by August 2026, and the Commission referred France to the Court of Justice in July 2026 over the delay. The practical consequence is that NIS2 currently reaches most organisations through contracts rather than through direct regulation: in-scope clients must secure their direct suppliers, and that arrives as security questionnaires, certification evidence, incident-notification clauses and sub-supplier disclosure regardless of transposition status.

Questions to ask on the day:

- Which obligations are currently creating the most procurement workload?
- Does SRS set common minimum controls for members and suppliers, or does each member apply its own?
- Where does SRS act as data controller, as processor, and as a shared service — and is that written down?

5. The procurement and data leader's world at SRS

The combined remit puts two different accountability logics on one desk.

The procurement side is accountable for value, supplier relationships, risk, continuity and sustainability, with priorities spanning cost, quality, speed, risk and innovation. Deloitte's research shows leading procurement organisations increasing investment in digital procurement and AI while treating risk and talent as core priorities, and identifies siloed working and capability limits as the material barriers — which is to say the constraint is usually organisational rather than a missing tool.

For an IT procurement lead specifically there is a tension the general procurement literature misses: technology categories are simultaneously the thing being purchased and the enabler of procurement transformation. Contract terms, data-processing arrangements, cybersecurity posture, implementation dependencies, vendor lock-in and product roadmaps therefore become everyday commercial decisions rather than specialist reviews.

The data and digital side shifts the accountability toward making data usable and governed, selecting use cases that scale, aligning technology to business outcomes, and establishing controls for AI-enabled work. Gartner's procurement research points explicitly to collaboration with data and analytics leaders to make procurement data AI-ready and governed — which, given that 74% of procurement leaders report their data is not AI-ready, is the work rather than a precondition for it.

In a combined role at a network organisation, the recurring workload sits at the seams: translating member requests into specifications, comparing options, checking vendor and contract evidence, reconciling data definitions across members, managing cross-functional approvals, and deciding which digital improvements can scale across organisations that did not agree on them in advance. None of that is decision-making in the sense a job description implies; most of it is preparation for decisions, and it is where the hours go.

Questions to ask on the day:

- Which metric matters most when you personally call a procurement or digital initiative successful?
- How much of your time goes to decisions versus preparation, evidence gathering and follow-up?
- Where do procurement, data and digital responsibilities join up, and where do they stay separate?

6. Peer signals

Kingfisher is the most current and most quantified comparison. In its year to 31 January 2026 it reported total sales of £12,945 million and capital expenditure of £388 million, up £71 million as it invested in technology and stores. Its AI-driven product recommendation and personalisation engines are live in every banner outside Iberia and account for around £165 million of group sales, up 40%. Its Core IQ insight platform, built on first-party data in Castorama France, is being rolled out to all banners during 2026, and it has brought retail media capability in-house with a group centre of excellence and a dedicated team per banner. On the supplier side it runs engagement surveys, risk-based ethical assessments, supply-chain resilience work, formal supplier data-protection controls and vendor-engagement risk assessment — procurement, data governance and AI controls meeting in the same operating environment.

Carrefour is the clearest procurement-specific AI case. Its 2025 universal registration document states that generative AI is used in purchasing to identify price-renegotiation opportunities and compare tenders, and it has launched an internal AI platform for document analysis and drafting. Separately, it co-founded the LESS platform with other retailers to harmonise and improve the reliability of suppliers' carbon data and build a consolidated view of supplier emissions — a direct precedent for the idea that supplier information problems are solved collectively rather than company by company, which is the SRS thesis applied to a single category.

Decathlon has described a global indirect-purchasing strategy, digitisation of indirect purchasing, critical-supplier risk criteria, external ESG assessment through EcoVadis, and a plan to automate sustainability criteria in tender management. Its wider reporting position is also instructive on the regulatory point above: it is transitioning during 2026 to a voluntary ESG report explicitly as preparation for full CSRD compliance for the 2027 financial year, which is the same timetable most large members will be on.

The common signal is not that every retailer uses the same technology. It is that procurement has become data-dependent: tender comparison, supplier risk, sustainability evidence and contract-facing decisions all improve when information is structured, comparable and available at the moment of decision — and several of these companies have concluded that some of that information is better assembled collectively than separately.

Questions to ask on the day:

- Which peer example is closest to the reality SRS is trying to create?
- Carrefour co-founded a shared platform for supplier carbon data. Is that a model for SRS or a competitor to it?
- Which peer practice would your teams most likely reject because it adds process rather than removing it?

7. Friction map

Requests arrive in different shapes. Procurement requests from different members and functions come in different formats, so time goes into clarifying what evidence is actually needed before any work can start — and the clarification often has to be repeated when the same category comes round again for a different member.

Supplier information is scattered and ages unevenly. It sits across documents, spreadsheets, portals and individual knowledge, so "the latest" in practice means "the latest I could find". Evidence collected for one function's control does not necessarily satisfy another's, and it changes at different speeds, so the same facts get revalidated repeatedly rather than reused.

Comparison is expensive. Tender responses are hard to compare when vendors answer different questions, use different assumptions or structure commercial terms differently, and normalising them consumes the part of the cycle that should be spent deciding. Cross-country buying adds translation, regulatory and terminology differences on top.

Standardisation and autonomy pull against each other. Shared categories create the economies of scale that justify the network, while member-specific requirements make standardisation hard to hold. Procurement, data and digital teams can agree on the outcome and still disagree about who owns definitions, controls and implementation effort.

Sustainability and risk evidence adds a second layer. It increasingly has to be checked against commercial information rather than filed separately, which means two sets of evidence with different owners and refresh cycles have to agree before a decision is defensible.

AI helps only downstream of the data problem. It reduces manual work when source information is structured, current and governed, and adds a review step when it is not — which is the practical meaning of three-quarters of procurement leaders reporting their data is not AI-ready.

And the knowledge does not accumulate. Supplier conversations generate genuinely useful intelligence that is hard to turn into reusable organisational memory, so central teams get pulled toward exception handling because the routine questions still need a human to check and chase.

Questions to ask on the day:

- Which two of these consume the most time today?
- Which one creates the most avoidable rework?
- Which is shared across most member organisations rather than being local?

Challenge cards

Card 1 of 2

Title: Compare bids without chasing

The challenge: Supplier responses need to be compared quickly, but the information rarely arrives in a genuinely comparable form. The tender, the vendor documents, the commercial assumptions and the follow-up emails all have to be checked before anyone can explain why one offer is stronger than another — and that normalisation work sits between receiving the responses and making the decision.

Who feels it: The IT procurement lead and the procurement team directly; requestors, finance, legal and digital teams waiting on the outcome; and the participating suppliers, who answer near-identical questions in near-identical ways for different members.

Why it persists: Tenders collect commercial, technical, security and service information that suppliers produce in different formats and at different levels of detail, and no single party controls the shape of the response. In a network the problem compounds, because the same supplier may be evaluated separately by several members against slightly different criteria.

What solved looks like: The team reaches a defensible comparison without spending large parts of the day normalising documents or chasing missing answers, and stakeholder questions are answered from the same evidence that produced the decision rather than from a reconstruction of it.

Evidence base: SRS's own 2026 recruitment material lists tender drafting and comparative analysis of offers as recurring project activity, alongside solution benchmarking and testing. Carrefour states in its 2025 universal registration document that it uses generative AI in purchasing to identify renegotiation opportunities and compare tenders. Deloitte's 2025 CPO survey identifies siloed working and execution capability among the leading barriers to procurement value.

Open question: How much of a typical technology sourcing cycle is spent turning supplier responses into a comparable view before the actual decision can be made?

Card 2 of 2

Title: Stop rechecking supplier evidence

The challenge: The same supplier facts get confirmed repeatedly — who the supplier is, what they provide, which evidence is current, what risks have been assessed, what still needs chasing. The work is often less about making the decision than about proving the information behind it is still

valid.

Who feels it: The procurement and data leadership who own the outcome; risk, legal, finance and sustainability functions each applying their own control; and member-organisation buyers who may be re-collecting evidence someone else in the network already holds.

Why it persists: Supplier evidence is collected for different purposes at different refresh rates, so one function's complete record does not satisfy another's control. The regulatory picture reinforces it: NIS2 supplier-security duties reach suppliers through client contracts regardless of France's transposition delay, and sustainability evidence requirements continue even after simplification — though the new value-chain cap now limits what can be demanded of suppliers under 1,000 employees and gives them a statutory right to decline, which is itself a piece of information the network needs to hold consistently.

What solved looks like: The team knows which supplier information is already trustworthy and current before asking for it again. Routine checks take less time, exceptions are visible enough that attention goes to the suppliers that genuinely need review, and the network's aggregate knowledge of a supplier is worth more than any single member's.

Evidence base: SRS spans more than 50 indirect-purchasing themes across nine activity families and describes its role as an interface with suppliers on behalf of member groups. Professional body material through 2025 and 2026 emphasises continuous supplier risk visibility, data hygiene and human oversight. Decathlon describes critical-supplier risk criteria and external ESG assessment; Kingfisher describes supplier engagement surveys, risk-based ethical assessments and formal supplier data-protection controls. The Omnibus I Directive's value-chain cap, and the revised ESRS adopted on 3 July 2026, change what may be asked of smaller suppliers.

Open question: Which supplier information gets requested or revalidated most often, even though someone in the network has probably already collected it?

Where this document is thin

- No public source provides SRS revenue, profit, headcount by function, financial statements or a formal strategy document.
- No public source identifies the current leadership team. Named individuals should not be inferred from third-party profiles.
- No public source establishes which member groups hold which ownership stakes, how shareholder governance works, or how decisions escalate across members. SRS's own language of "more than 20 shareholder groups" is the safest formulation.

- The relationship between SRS and the Association Familiale Mulliez is not stated publicly. The Croix registered address and the naming of Leroy Merlin, Auchan and Decathlon as member banners are suggestive but not conclusive, and the "more than one hundred distribution banners" figure comes from recruitment material rather than from SRS's own site.
- The two headcount figures SRS publishes — 1,500 collaborators from shareholder groups, and more than 1,000 member collaborators in the purchasing community — are different measures and their relationship is not explained.
- No public source reveals the technology stack, data architecture, procurement systems, AI models, current vendor contracts or internal performance indicators.
- A member-facing application exists at the SRS domain, but nothing public establishes its adoption, production status, user numbers or business impact, and the 2026 platform described in recruitment material cannot be assumed to be live.
- The attendee's precise objectives, reporting line, budget authority and team size are not public.
- Whether SRS acts as data controller, processor or neither in respect of member and supplier data is not documented anywhere public, and it materially affects the GDPR position.
- Whether SRS or any member is in scope for NIS2 depends on activity, size and national implementation, none of which can be determined from public sources.